

EXP 2 - SETTING UP A ZOHO CREATOR ACCOUNT AND EXPLORING THE PLATFORM ARCHITECTURE AND INTERFACE

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Aim:

To create and set up a Zoho Creator account, develop a sample Service Management System using forms, reports and dashboards, and explore the Develop, Deploy and Manage sections of the Zoho Creator platform.

Setting up Zoho Creator:

I) Create the Sample Application

1. Open a web browser and visit the Zoho Creator website.
2. Sign in using a Zoho account or create a new account.
3. Click Create Application and select Create from Scratch.
4. Enter the application name as Service Management System.
5. Create the required forms for the application.

The sample Service Management System contains forms such as Department, Asset Details, Technician, Maintenance Request, Maintenance Approval and Repair Progress.

II) Creating Form, Report and Dashboard

A. Creating a Form

A form is used to collect and store data in the Zoho Creator application. Forms can contain different field types such as single line, number, date, dropdown and lookup.

Procedure:

1. Open the Service Management System application.
2. Go to the Develop section.
3. Select Form and create a new form.
4. Add the required fields and configure their properties.
5. Save the form and enter sample records.

Form Creation

The screenshot shows a form builder interface for a 'Service Management System' with a 'Department' form. The interface is divided into three main sections:

- Basic Fields:** A sidebar on the left containing various field types: Name, Email, Address, Phone, Single Line, Multi Line, Number, Date, Time, and Drop Down.
- Form Design:** The central workspace where fields are added. It shows a 'Department ID' field (highlighted with a blue dashed border), followed by 'Department Location', 'Department Name', and 'Department head' (marked with a red asterisk). A '2/3' indicator is visible below the 'Department head' field.
- Field Properties:** A sidebar on the right for configuring the selected field. It includes:
 - Field name:** 'Department ID'
 - Field link name:** 'Department_ID'
 - View Field References:** A link to view references.
 - Validation:** A 'Start index' field set to '1'.
 - Appearance:** A 'Field type' dropdown menu set to 'Auto Number'.

Explanation: The form builder is used to design data-entry screens and collect information from users in a structured manner.

B. Creating a Report

A report is used to display and analyze records submitted through forms. Reports can be used to search, sort, filter and view application data.

Procedure:

6. Open the application.
7. Go to the Develop section and select Report.
8. Select the required form as the data source.
9. Choose a suitable report format.
10. Configure the fields, filters and sorting options.
11. Save the report.

Report Creation

The screenshot displays the 'Service Management System' interface. On the left is a dark sidebar with a menu containing 'Department', 'Department Report' (highlighted), 'Asset Details', 'Technician', 'Maintenance Request', 'Maintenance Approval', 'Repair Progress', 'AI', and 'Service management Dashboard'. The main area is titled 'Department Report' and contains a table with the following data:

Department ID	Department Name	Department head	Department Location
5	Administration	Suresh Kumar	Block E
4	Sales	Kavitha Devi	Block - D
3	Finance	Arun Prakash	Block C
2	HR	Priya Sharma	Block B
1	IT	Rajesh Kumar	Block A

At the bottom of the table area, it says 'Showing 5 of 5'. The top of the interface includes a header with 'Service Management System', a trial expiration notice 'Trial expires in 11 days', and links for 'Upgrade', 'Edit this application', and 'Help'.

Explanation: The report displays stored application records in an organized format and helps users view and analyze the data.

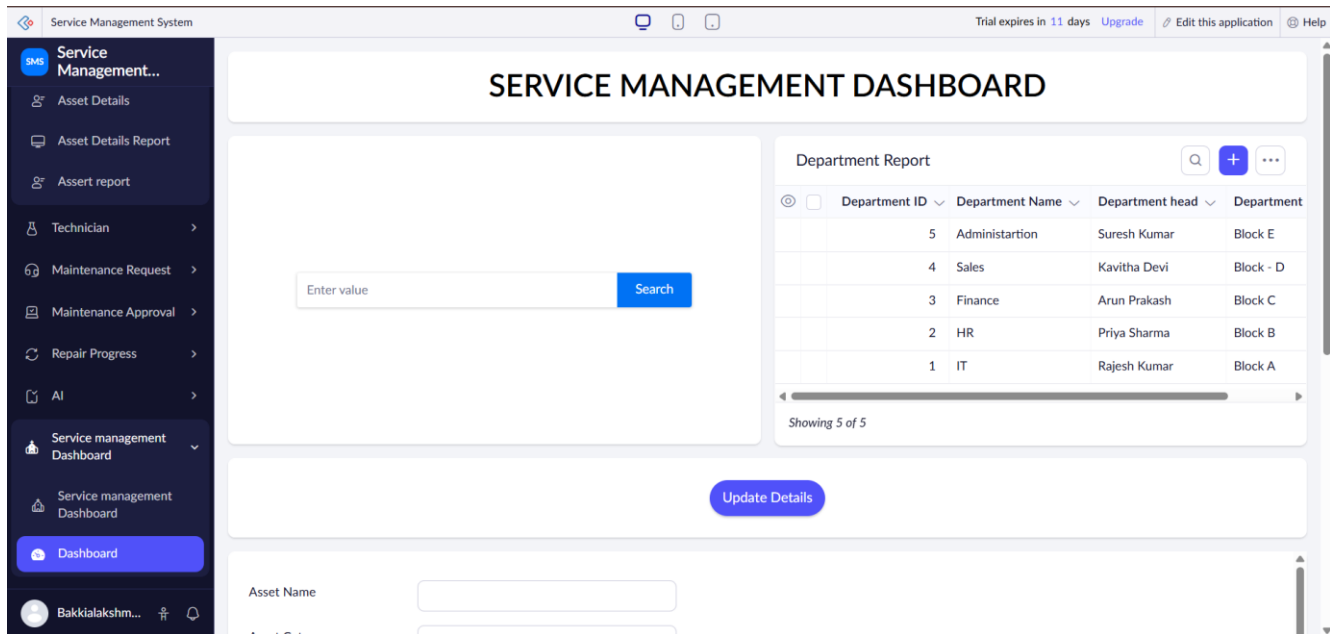
C. Creating a Dashboard

A dashboard provides a visual summary of important application information. It can contain panels, reports, charts and other components.

Procedure:

12. Open the Service Management System application.
13. Go to Pages and create a new page.
14. Open the ZML Editor or Page Builder.
15. Create dashboard sections for important information.
16. Add suitable panels, reports and charts.
17. Save and preview the dashboard.

Dashboard



Explanation: The dashboard gives users a quick overview of the Service Management System and can be used to monitor assets, technicians, maintenance requests and repair activities.

Exploring the Platform Architecture and Interface:

Zoho Creator provides a low-code environment for building, deploying and managing business applications. The platform can be broadly understood through the following three stages:

i) Develop

- The Develop section is used to build applications using forms, reports, pages, workflows and other components.
- Forms collect data, while reports and dashboards display and analyze the collected information.
- Workflows and Deluge scripts can be used to automate processes and implement application logic.

ii) Deploy

- The Deploy stage makes the developed application available to authorized users.
- Users can access the application through supported web and application interfaces.
- User permissions and access settings can be configured according to the application requirements.

iii) Manage

- The Manage section is used to administer and maintain the application after development.
- Administrators can manage users, permissions, application settings and data.
- Monitoring and maintenance help ensure that the application continues to operate correctly.

Result:

Thus, a Zoho Creator account was successfully set up and a sample Service Management System application was created. Forms, reports and dashboards were explored, and the Develop, Deploy and Manage sections of the Zoho Creator platform architecture and interface were studied successfully.